A DUNGEONS & DRAGONS ONE-SHOT CAMPAIGN

THE
Holiday Heist

A One-Shot Adventure in the World Beyond the Snowglobe

Designed for 4-5 Players at Level 2
One-Shot Adventure

ADVENTURE SYNOPSIS

A band of morally flexible adventurers follows a trail of suspicious elves through a magical portal and finds themselves trapped inside a living snowglobe — the winter domain of Saint Nicholas himself. The reindeer are missing, the workshop is empty, a blizzard rages on the second floor, and the elves are imprisoned in the cellar. Standing between the party and answers is Krampus, ancient nemesis of holiday cheer, who has taken Nicholas hostage and unleashed his minions on the castle. What began as a casual heist becomes a race to save the holiday.

Written by
Bradley Charles

ADVENTURE OVERVIEW

Players	4-5 Players
Level	2nd Level Characters
Duration	3-4 Hours
Tone	Whimsical, comedic, with genuine stakes
Themes	Holiday magic, heist gone sideways, reluctant heroism
Setting	A living snowglobe — the winter domain of Saint Nicholas

DM Guidance

The Holiday Heist is a complete one-shot holiday adventure. The players begin with zero heroic motivation — they followed some elves for profit and ended up somewhere magical and strange. By the end, despite themselves, they will have saved the holiday.

Let the players lean into their mercenary instincts early. The moral shift happens naturally: the imprisoned elves, the worried faces, the sight of Saint Nicholas in chains. Nobody asks the party to become heroes. They just kind of end up being ones.

DESIGNER NOTES
Death saves are private to the DM.
Players only roll when there is a clear consequence.
Perception checks and similar investigative rolls are made by the DM — players don't get meta-information from the die result.
Soft failure outcomes are always hooks, never dead ends. Every failed roll points somewhere useful.

Spell Adjustments

All magic in the snowglobe domain carries a holiday flavor. The players' spells still function normally, but they feel different — threads of power taste like peppermint, fire crackles with a faint cinnamon scent, teleportation leaves a trail of snowflakes. Flavor all magic this way and encourage the players to describe their spells in festive terms.

The party's equipment has also been transformed: cloaks gain silver filigree and embroidered snowflakes, boots are trimmed in white fur, weapons hum with festive metalwork. None of these changes affect mechanics — they are purely aesthetic, and entirely intentional on the part of whatever power rules this place.

THE OPENING NARRATIVE

Read or paraphrase the following aloud to your players. This sets the tone: irreverent adventurers, a strange magical accident, and suddenly things have gotten very real.

READ ALOUD

The last few weeks had been quiet — too quiet for a band of adventurers whose moral compasses tended to wobble in the general direction of "crime, but for the fun of it." Which is why the rogue's ears perked up the moment he overheard frantic whispering in a dingy tavern corner. A cluster of tiny elves — real elves, not the long-lived lofty kind, but pint-sized creatures in pointy hats — were gathering strange, rare supplies, stuffing them into sacks, and hurrying off with the urgency of people who absolutely did not want to be followed.

Naturally, your group followed them.

It took a day's travel through the backwoods, then another half-day of bickering and getting lost before you finally picked up the trail again. When you spot them at last, you see them slip into a cave hidden behind a curtain of brambles. You hid just outside, prepared to ambush the elves when they exit — but impatience won out. Time to liberate these creatures of their obviously valuable goods.

You rush into the cave expecting a fight. Instead, you step straight into someone's reading room.

A warm, cozy den sat carved into the stone. A crackling fireplace. A rocking chair sitting completely still. Stockings hung with care. A coffee table with a single book resting perfectly centered atop it. There were no elves. No crates of magical goodies. Not even a footprint in the snow-dusted carpet.

You searched the chamber anyway — because hope springs eternal when gold is involved — but found nothing except that lonely book. The rogue, naturally, touched it.

The book snapped open with a life of its own. Pages fluttered like frantic wings, stopping on a story about Saint Nicholas, his workshop, and the toys crafted every year by his loyal elves. Someone snorted. Someone else said, "Robbing Saint Nicholas would be the heist of the century." And everyone laughed.

The moment you stepped through the cave mouth... the world changed.

The forest was no longer there. In its place stretched a snow-blanketed landscape under a pale winter sky. This is where your story begins.

PART ONE: THE EXTERIOR GROUNDS

READ ALOUD

Snow drifts down in slow, careful spirals, each flake falling with the same measured grace. The air is crisp and perfectly still — no wind, no shifting chill, just a gentle cold that never deepens or fades.

Ahead, far across a wide blanket of unbroken snow, rises a massive ice castle, its towers gleaming like frozen starlight. Even from this distance, the spires stretch impossibly high, catching every glimmer of the pale sky.

To your right, the stables — a long, low structure with a pitched snow-laden roof. The doors sit slightly ajar. Beside it stands a large barn, taller and more solid, frost rimming its heavy double doors in a crisp, bright line that almost glows.

The whole landscape is breathtaking… but it feels curated, arranged with intention, as if the world is waiting for you to play your part.

The players will also notice something unsettling about their own abilities. The spells they have practiced sit in their minds like rearranged ornaments — familiar shapes, but different colors. Magic cast here carries a holiday flavor. Threads of power taste like peppermint or crackle like frost.

Their gear has been transformed as well. Cloaks bear silver filigree and embroidered snowflakes. Boots are trimmed in white fur. Weapons hum with festive metalwork. Someone wanted them festive, bright, and ready for a story.

Area 1: The Stables

The stables are immaculate — too immaculate for somewhere supposedly abandoned. Everything inside has been recently tended with obvious love and care. The reindeer themselves are gone, but their absence feels deliberate rather than chaotic.

DM NOTE: THE STABLES
The snowglobe's magic affects the weather and the untouched snow — not the stables themselves.
The stables look perfect because the elves maintain them. The elves are mysteriously missing.
The reindeer vanished, but everything else is lovingly tended — as if the elves stepped away only moments ago.
There is no combat here. This is an investigation and atmosphere zone.

Use the following skill check table to guide player exploration:

Investigation (DC 12-14)	On Failure
SUCCESS	**SOFT HINT**
Signs of recent care are evident: freshly laid hay that hasn't settled, tools arranged with no dust, water troughs scrubbed clean and still liquid despite the cold. Clue: The elves tended this area very recently.	The stable is immaculate but empty. Everything feels too perfectly arranged for a place supposedly abandoned. Soft nudge: If the elves aren't here, where did they go?

Nature (DC 12)	On Failure
SUCCESS	**SOFT HINT**
Bedding shows impressions of reindeer resting within the last day. Fur in the hay suggests healthy, calm animals — not panicked. Clue: The animals didn't bolt. They were led away intentionally.	You cannot identify the reindeer's behavior, but the bedding isn't old. The feed isn't stale. Soft nudge: Whoever tended this expected the reindeer to come back soon.

Perception (DC 13)	On Failure
SUCCESS	**SOFT HINT**
Tiny elf footprints in the stable dust — light, small steps made after the reindeer vanished. A faint sweet scent of sugar and peppermint lingers on the walls. Clue: Something interrupted the elves mid-task.	No footprints visible, but you notice small signs of elf handiwork: a comb on a peg, a feeding scoop turned precisely the same way at every stall. Soft nudge: Someone with very small hands was just here.

Arcana (DC 14)	On Failure
SUCCESS	**SOFT HINT**
You detect background magic connected to the snowglobe itself — the weather, the unnatural stillness. But the stables? Mundane. Maintained not by magic, but by careful hands. Clue: The perfection here is craftsmanship, not enchantment.	You sense the snowglobe's ambient magic but can't parse the stables. They don't 'hum' the way the ground and sky do. Soft nudge: Something in this environment is magical — but not this building.

Survival (DC 13)	On Failure
SUCCESS	**SOFT HINT**
Faint reindeer prints beneath the top layer of snow — but they vanish abruptly, as if the creatures were led toward the barn and then removed by other means. Clue: The barn or another controlled area is the next place to look.	Something is off about the snow: too even, too perfect. It doesn't behave like real snow — you can't track the reindeer through it. Soft nudge: Look for better clues in areas not covered in snow, like the barn doors.

Area 2: The Barn

The barn carries a strange pressure in the atmosphere — the air around it feels thicker, older somehow. The heavy double doors are sealed shut with frost, but resist not with the stiffness of wood and ice but with a soft, unmistakable pushback. Like a hand gently refusing entry.

The enchantment is not hostile. It is a memory of Saint Nicholas — his warmth, his cheer, his generosity, the soft winter magic he carries. Over centuries, that feeling became embedded in the wood itself. The doors open only when someone evokes that same signature.

The Enchanted Door Puzzle

The magic is not looking for a person. It is looking for a feeling.

Let players piece together the nature of the ward through skill checks, then give them multiple ways to solve it. The puzzle rewards creativity, roleplay, and teamwork — not a single die roll.

CLUES PLAYERS CAN DISCOVER
Warmth weakens the ward.
Cheerful, comforting magic softens its glow.
Cold seasonal magic (like Frost Mage spells) produces the same reaction Nicholas' magic would.
The enchantment is benevolent, not defensive.
Animals sense something 'kind' but 'not for them' and treat the barn with quiet respect.

Arcana (DC 14-16)	On Failure
SUCCESS	**SOFT HINT**
The enchantment is tied to warmth, winter magic, and goodwill — the emotional fingerprints of Saint Nicholas. Cold and holiday-themed magic interacts with it harmoniously. Clue: Mimicking this 'signature' is possible.	The spell doesn't reveal its nature, but you sense it isn't hostile. You hear a whispery shimmer — like frost forming. Soft nudge: Cold magic might interact with it.

Investigation (DC 12-14)	On Failure
SUCCESS	**SOFT HINT**
Snowflake sigils along the seam are perfectly symmetrical. The frost near the sigils responds slightly when you breathe warm air or press a heated hand closer. Clue: Warmth or 'kindness magic' weakens the barrier.	You see the sigils but can't interpret them. One changes shade briefly when someone laughs or speaks warmly nearby. Soft nudge: Cheer, joy, or kindness affects the ward.

Performance / Persuasion (DC 13-14)	On Failure
SUCCESS	**SOFT HINT**
A cheerful effort — singing a winter tune, telling a wholesome story, offering Candy — causes the sigils to shimmer like crystals catching dawn light. The doors relax slightly. The ward is visibly weakening.	Nothing opens, but the frost patterns soften for a moment, like they're listening. Soft nudge: Maybe it needs more than one person, or more sincerity.

Solving the Puzzle

Players can combine warm spells, kind acts, and holiday cheer. When they work together — a group Performance or Arcana check (DC 13-15) — the ward responds strongly. The sigils glow warm-white, frost patterns melt, hinges hum gently, and the doors swing open like welcoming an old friend.

The following also work as partial unlocks that combine toward the solution:

- Sharing Candy (Goodberry reskin): Warms the frost symbols, making them glow faintly.
- Dancing Lights arranged to mimic falling snow: Reveals the snowflake sigil in full detail.
- Winter's Mark cast on the doors: Marks something behind the doors, hinting the ward is powered by a presence inside.
- Mage Armor: The abjuration aura makes the ward pulse with familiarity — close, but the 'emotion' behind the magic is still needed.
- A genuine act of generosity with no mechanical benefit: The barn recognizes the spirit behind the gesture and opens willingly.

Area 3: The Barn Interior

The barn interior is dim, lit only by thin beams of white daylight slipping through the high rafters. Dust motes swirl lazily in warm air.

> **READ ALOUD**
> *Sitting in the center of the barn on a raised wooden platform is a magnificent red sled. A sleigh — sleek and graceful, lacquered in deep crimson and trimmed with polished gold. Intricate patterns of snowflakes and swirling lines run along the sides, glowing faintly as if inlaid with their own quiet magic. Golden runners curve up at the front, honed to a mirror shine. You can see your own distorted reflections in them.*
> *Near the corner, a large green tarp covers a bulky object — a crate releasing a steady, warm light through its slats.*

The workbench along one wall holds tools for caring for great winter beasts: wide-toothed combs, curved hoof scrapers, and neatly stacked cloths. Metal tins are labeled in curling script: antler oil,

hoof balm, winter salve, frostbite remedy. Several harness pieces sit half-assembled, as if someone stepped away mid-task.

The Hearthstar Core

MAGICAL ITEM: THE HEARTHSTAR CORE
Appearance: A grapefruit-sized crystal shaped like a faceted ember of firelight. Warm to the touch, glowing like a tiny hearth.
Radiates comforting warmth in a 20-ft area.
Emits harmless floating sparks like drifting fireflies.
Can rekindle any mundane fire instantly.
Works as a magical light that never burns out.
PLOT FUNCTION: This is the power source that warms the sleigh. The elves will supercharge it with their magic so the party can pass through the blizzard on the second floor.
In combat: DC 12 check to use it; successful use deals 1 radiant damage to Krampus and gives him disadvantage on attacks until his next turn.

PART TWO: THE CASTLE FIRST FLOOR

READ ALOUD — CASTLE APPROACH

The snow-covered path leads you toward a towering castle of frosted stone, its tall spires gleaming like sculpted ice. Warm golden light glows in high windows, a strange contrast to the still, silent air. Two massive winter-oak doors rise nearly three stories high, carved with scenes of elves at work and trimmed with faintly glowing gold filigree. An arch of evergreen branches drapes over the doorway, dotted with soft, pulsing red berries. There is no guard, no noise — only the warm scent of cinnamon and sugar drifting from within, inviting and unsettling all at once.

The Workshop

The workshop opens into a wide, bright hall filled with long wooden tables in tidy rows. Every surface is covered with half-finished toys, colorful fabrics, gears, tiny tools, and jars of shimmering materials. Nothing is scattered or messy — every project looks as if it was paused mid-craft, as though the elves stepped away only seconds before you arrived.

The room is too quiet. No footprints. No signs of struggle. Just the work of many hands frozen in place, leaving the party surrounded by dozens of almost-finished creations and the uncanny feeling that the workshop is waiting for someone to finish what was started.

The Sleeping Quarters

A narrow, cozy room lined with bunk beds stacked five high along both walls. Each small mattress is neatly made with a colorful patchwork blanket, tucked so precisely it's hard to imagine anyone ever slept in them at all. The room is completely silent.

The Kitchen

A warm, spacious kitchen filled with long counters and brick ovens built for steady, cheerful work. The scent of cinnamon and sweet pastries lingers, but everything is perfectly clean and still. Mixing bowls stacked neatly. Wooden spoons in careful rows. Trays ready for baking. It feels like the elves stepped away only moments ago.

In the back corner, a tall shelving rack stuffed with pots and jars sits slightly apart from the wall. Behind it — concealed by the rack — is a narrow doorway barely wide enough for an elf. The rack swings aside on a hidden hinge. This is where the supply-run elves are hiding. See The Kitchen Reunion section.

The Staircase

Looking up the staircase, you don't see the second floor. Instead, a churning blizzard hangs in the air where the upper landing should be — snow twisting in violent spirals, shards of ice flashing through the storm, winds whipping hard enough to bend the drifting flakes into streaks of white. A full winter gale contained within a single space. Yet the party feels none of its cold.

The storm rages in complete silence. No wind touches their skin. No frost clings to the railing. It is as though the blizzard is behind a pane of invisible glass, furious but distant, refusing to let anything pass through. Until the party charges the Hearthstar Core with the elves' magic, this passage is blocked.

The Washroom

The warm glow and sugary scents of the workshop fade immediately upon crossing the threshold. The air is colder here — not freezing, but empty, like a room that hasn't been breathed in for far too long. Shadows pool thicker than they should.

On the far wall stands a wooden door made of thick planks and iron fittings. It isn't locked. It isn't barred. But it feels wrong. The wood is too dark, the iron too cold, and a faint draft seeps through the cracks carrying a scent that prickles the back of the throat.

This door leads down to the cellar.

PART THREE: THE CELLAR

READ ALOUD

The moment the cellar door gives way, a foul wave of air rolls over you — sour, smoky, and unmistakably wrong. Lantern light glints off shattered barrels at the bottom of the stairs, arranged into a crude fire pit.

Beyond the pit sits a massive cage, hammered together from bits of fencing, broken shelving, and twisted iron. Inside, packed shoulder to shoulder, are elves. Some sit slumped in exhaustion. Some stare wide-eyed at you. Some lie too still to be sleeping.

Sprawled outside the cage are the creatures responsible: thick-limbed, crooked-mouthed things. Their claws are stained, their faces smeared, and every one of them lies unconscious in a drunken heap, bellies bloated with stolen brandy. They snore like clogged chimneys, twitching occasionally, reeking of liquor and malice dulled only by stupor.

The Cellar: Encounter Options

The party has several valid approaches to this situation. Each one leads somewhere interesting. The sleeping Drunken Gremlins give the players a strong initial advantage regardless of which path they choose.

Option A: Stealthy Rescue

Group Stealth check. Characters may gain advantage by timing movements between snores. On success, they reach the cage unnoticed and free the elves quietly. The elves warn them about the blizzard upstairs and the Hearthstar Core. On failure, one minion stirs — but no catastrophe. The moment becomes a tense decision point, not a penalty.

Option B: Silent Takedown

Individual Stealth checks to get into position, then Attack rolls with advantage against sleeping targets. On success, they drop multiple minions before the fight begins. On failure, a grunt or yelp wakes several — who stagger to their feet with disadvantage on initiative from the lingering brandy.

Option C: The Direct Approach

The party gets a guaranteed surprise round. Once the fight begins, the minions' drunkenness shapes the battlefield: they attack recklessly, stumble prone, occasionally hit one another, and may vomit brandy on the ground creating difficult terrain slick zones.

Option D: Environmental Shenanigans

The cellar is a playground. Players can collapse shattered barrels into a barricade, use the brandy-soaked floor to create fire hazards, tie minions with rope or old aprons, or flip the improvised cage so it traps the minions instead of the elves.

Option E: Negotiation

Yes, even with these creatures. The minions are drunk enough to slur confused answers if roused gently. They won't be loyal, but they might be bribable and are certainly stupid. This path can drop lore hooks without rewarding violence.

> **DRUNKEN GREMLIN (IF GENTLY ROUSED)**
> *"We weren't... hic... supposed to eat all of 'em..."*
> *"Krampus said... said no witnesses... or was it no whistles...?"*
> *"Did you bring more brandy?"*

Environmental Hazards

BRANDY-SLICK FLOOR
Areas around shattered barrels are soaked with flammable alcohol.
Moving through: DC 10 Dex (Acrobatics) or fall prone.
If ignited: The 10x10 area deals 1d4 fire damage.
Affects minions and players equally.

SMOLDERING FIREPIT
A shallow circular pit made of barrel fragments.
If a creature is shoved in: 1d6 fire damage, plus a minion takes disadvantage as smoke burns their eyes.

IMPROVISED ELF CAGE
Break the lock: DC 12 Strength
Bend the bars: DC 14 Strength
Pick the lock with improvised tools: DC 14 Dex
Failure on any of the above: Makes noise, one minion stirs.

TOPPLING STORAGE SHELVES
DC 12 Strength to topple, creating a 10-ft crush zone.

Creatures in zone: DC 12 Dex save or take 1d6 bludgeoning and become restrained until freed.
Minions have disadvantage on saves while waking.

BRANDY VAPOR FLASH
If a fire spell or open flame hits a heavily soaked patch: Ignition!
A 5x5 zone detonates for 1d6 fire damage, DC 12 Dex save.
Sleeping minions awaken screaming. Possibly on fire.

BESTIARY

Drunken Gremlin

Drunken Gremlin

Small fiend (corrupted fey), Chaotic Evil
AC 12 HP 9 (2d6+2) Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	6 (−2)	8 (−1)	6 (−2)

Saving Throws: Dex +4
Skills: Stealth +4
Senses: Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 9
Languages: Broken Elvish, Abyssal curses
Challenge: 1/4 each (easy-medium encounter when grouped)

Traits

Drunken Stupor.

Minions who are asleep have disadvantage on Perception and Dexterity saves for the first round after waking. In combat, this manifests as stumbling, falling prone, or swinging wildly.

Clumsy Rage (Recharge 5-6).

On its turn, the minion may attack recklessly, gaining advantage on its next attack — but all attacks against it also have advantage until its next turn.

Brandy-Fueled Breath.

If reduced to 0 HP, the minion lets out a volatile belch. The nearest adjacent creature must succeed on a DC 10 Dex save or take 1 fire damage as the minion's brandy-soaked breath ignites.

Actions

Slashing Claws.

Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6+2) slashing damage.

Bottle Bash.

If the minion can grab a stray bottle, mug, or barrel scrap. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit; 1d4+2 bludgeoning damage.

ENCOUNTER BALANCING: CELLAR BRAWL
4 Gremlins = Easy to Medium difficulty
5 Gremlins = Medium difficulty
6 Gremlins = Slightly dangerous but fair given their drunken penalties
All gremlins start prone, asleep, and unarmed — the party gets a guaranteed surprise round if they choose violence.

Krampus Minion

Krampus Minion

Small fiend (corrupted fey), Chaotic Evil
AC 12 HP 9 (2d6+2) Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	6 (−2)	8 (−1)	6 (−2)

Actions

Slashing Claws.

Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6+2) slashing damage.

Snowblast (Recharge 5-6).

Ranged Spell Attack: +3 to hit, range 30 ft. Hit: 1d4+1 cold damage. Target has disadvantage on its next attack roll.

PART FOUR: THE RESCUED ELVES

When the players free the elves — whether quietly or after a brawl — the little workers are dazed, frightened, and grateful. Their answers come haltingly, shaped by confusion and deep loyalty to Saint Nicholas.

Why Were the Elves in the Cellar?

WIZZLE BRANDYWHISTLE (OR ANY ELF)

"Two days ago, Saint Nicholas came to us. He looked worried. We have never seen him like that. He gathered every elf in the workshop and told us to go down to the cellar. He said something was coming to the castle — something he didn't want us to face. He told us to hide and stay quiet, no matter what."

"And when Nicholas tells us something, we listen. He's the most important person in the world. He brings joy to millions. If he says hide, then we hide."

"We stayed down there for a whole day. Then the creatures came. They trapped us. We didn't see Nicholas again."

About the Supply-Run Elves

ANY RESCUED ELF

"Some of us were out on a supply run — fetching rare materials we use in the clockwork toys. They should have returned before Nicholas sounded the hiding order. They must have come in through the kitchen's back door, the one we use to take treats to the reindeer."

"If they made it into the castle at all... they might be hiding. Somewhere small. Somewhere only elves would fit."

About the Blizzard Upstairs

ANY ELF WHO HEARS ABOUT THE BLIZZARD

"The storm on the second floor is wrong. Nothing natural could be that strong."

"There's only one thing in the workshop powerful enough to get someone through something like that: the Hearthstar Core."

If Shown the Hearthstar Core

THE ELVES, EXAMINING THE CORE

"This is the Core, yes... but it feels weak. Like its light has dimmed."

"We can help. Cheer magic comes from us. From all of us. Together we can strengthen it."

> *"There. That should do it. With this, you can pass through the blizzard. Nothing that cold can dim Hearthstar light — not when it's shining properly."*

WHAT THE ELVES CANNOT ANSWER
What Nicholas feared.
Where he went.
Who or what took the castle.
How the blizzard started.
Why the minions invaded.
Their ignorance is intentional and honest. They trust Nicholas absolutely. Keep the mystery intact while giving the party direction, emotional grounding, and a sense of purpose.

The Kitchen Reunion

After freeing the imprisoned elves, they will guide the party to the kitchen. In the back corner, a tall shelving rack conceals a hidden pantry. Behind it, several elves from the supply run are huddled under blankets. The reunion is brief, warm, and emotionally genuine.

Once they've calmed, the supply-run elves confirm they were the ones the players followed from the caves. They were returning with rare clockwork components when the blizzard and strange creatures appeared. They hid because this is the only space in the castle too small for the gremlins to reach.

PART FIVE: THE SECOND FLOOR

READ ALOUD — PUSHING THROUGH THE BLIZZARD

As you push through the roaring wall of blizzard, the Hearthstar Core struggles at first, pulsing warm light that pushes back against the frozen magic. Every step is a strain. The air feels thick and heavy, as if the storm itself is trying to hold you in place. But slowly, the resistance fades.

You stand on the threshold of a vast hall that should feel festive — garlands frozen in place, ribbons caught mid-flutter in sheets of ice. A glow from the Core reveals veins of icy magic snaking in every direction, all of it spiraling toward a single point at the far end of the chamber.

A tall, twisted silhouette peels itself out of the gloom. Fur black as chimney soot. Curved horns like frosted steel. Hooves planted in rime-covered stone. And those eyes — two coals burning a baleful, furious red, bright enough to cast their own light. Krampus stands perfectly still, as if he has been watching you for much longer than you have been watching him.

Krampus tilts his head — curious, hungry, or both — and the red of his eyes brightens.

ROLL FOR INITIATIVE

Terrain Effects

- Slippery Ice: If a creature moves 10+ ft in one turn, DC 10 Acrobatics or speed becomes 0 for that turn (no prone, just stopped).
- Frozen Obstacles: Tables provide half cover.
- Hearthstar Pulse Zone: 10-ft aura around the Core when actively used.

Combat Sequence

ROUND 1
Krampus uses ranged attacks, testing the party.
When the player holding the Hearthstar is hit, they drop it and the blizzard begins to encroach again.
Krampus comments that he expected the Core to be drained by now.
Someone must spend their action steadying the Hearthstar each turn it's unattended.
Players can use the Core (DC 12 check) to deal 1 radiant damage to Krampus and give him disadvantage.
No minions yet. Nicholas still trapped.

ROUND 2
Elves arrive from side door.
They perform support actions: granting advantage, minor healing, minion sabotage.
Krampus may use Frightful Glare (DC 11 Wis or frightened 1 round).
The cage holding Nicholas rattles ominously.

END OF ROUND 2 / ROUND 3
Elves free Nicholas.
He emerges and immediately casts Icy Shield on an ally.
Krampus becomes more aggressive and advances.

ROUNDS 3-4
Nicholas casts Frostbite Spark or Glitterburst.
Krampus falls to half HP and creates a storm rift — Minions appear (2-3 Snowbound Imps).
Elves automatically distract at least one minion.
Nicholas shouts warnings and may use Binding Ribbon.

ROUNDS 5-6 AND FINAL ROUND
Hearthstar Core has likely been used 2-3 times.
Krampus is weakening fast. He may attempt Chain Sweep.
When Krampus reaches 10 HP or less, he FLEES:
- Uses Chain Sweep to clear a path
- Opens a storm rift
- Retreats while snarling threats about returning
- Encounter ends.

DM ADJUSTMENT: IF PLAYERS STRUGGLE
Have Nicholas cast a second Icy Shield or an extra Glitterburst.
Have the elves dogpile a minion completely.
Lower Krampus's HP by 5 silently.

DM ADJUSTMENT: IF PLAYERS STEAMROLL
Have Krampus summon an extra imp.

Have the ice floor crack, limiting movement.
Give Krampus one final roar dealing 1 cold damage to all creatures.

NPC STATISTICS

Wizard Nicholas (Weakened Form)

Wizard Nicholas

Medium Humanoid (Human), Neutral Good
AC 12 HP 13 Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (−1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)

Spell Attack: +4
Save DC: 12

Actions

Frostbite Spark (Cantrip, At Will).

Ranged Spell Attack: +4 to hit, 1d6 cold. On hit: target has disadvantage on its next attack.

Binding Ribbon (1/day).

Krampus makes DC 12 Strength save or is restrained until the end of Nicholas's next turn. On success, Krampus still takes 1 radiant damage.

Glitterburst (1/day).

One ally gains advantage on their next attack. The target glitters faintly, granting advantage to all attacks against it until Nicholas's next turn.

Icy Shield (1/day).

One ally gains +2 AC until the end of their next turn.

Reaction

Faltering Light.

When a creature within 15 ft drops to 0 HP, Nicholas stabilizes them instantly.

Krampus (Weakened Form)

Krampus

Large Fiend (Unique), Chaotic Evil

AC 15 HP 45 (weakened by Hearthstar Core) Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)

Traits

Blizzardbound.

Disadvantage on attacks next round if the Hearthstar Core is used successfully against him.

Hearthstar Vulnerability.

Each successful Core use deals 1 radiant damage and reduces his maximum HP by 3 (up to three times total).

Actions

Shadowlash.

Ranged Spell Attack +4, range 30 ft. Hit: 1d4+2 cold damage; DC 11 Con save or target has disadvantage on their next attack.

Hooking Claw.

Melee Attack +5, reach 10 ft. Hit: 1d6+3 slashing. Target must succeed DC 11 Strength save or be pulled 5 ft closer.

Chain Sweep (Recharge 4 turns).

All creatures in a 10-ft arc make DC 12 Dex save. Fail: 1d6 cold and pushed 10 ft back. Success: half damage only.

Special Abilities

Frightful Glare (1/encounter).

DC 11 Wis save or frightened for 1 round.

Summon Minions (triggered at 50% HP).

Krampus summons 2-3 Snowbound Imps from a storm rift.

GIFTS FROM SAINT NICHOLAS

At the end of the adventure, Saint Nicholas presents each hero with a gift — a personal keepsake tuned to their class, their personality, and their contribution to the victory. These are small, permanent magical items appropriate for Level 2 characters. They are meant to be personal, not just mechanical: something each player will want to hold onto.

ORC BARBARIAN

The Frost-Forged Hearthstone

A fist-sized crystal of pale blue quartz, shot through with gentle white light. The surface is warm despite its icy color. When held, it hums in time with the Barbarian's heartbeat.

Mechanical Effect

Once per long rest, when you enter Rage, you may choose to unleash the stone's warmth. Your Rage gains one of the following until it ends: • Frosthide: You gain resistance to cold damage and +1 AC. • Blizzard Rush: Your movement speed increases by 10 ft and you leave swirling snow that lightly obscures a 5-ft trail until your next turn.

Flavor

Nicholas fashioned it from the same magic that powers the Hearthstar — raw resilience, warmth in the cold, and a stubborn refusal to die out.

Future Hook

The Hearthstone grows brighter when Krampus is near. It will one day crack open and reveal something inside.

HUMAN FROST-MAGE WIZARD

The Northwind Codex Fragment

A single page torn from one of Nicholas's ancient tomes. The parchment shifts between runes, snowflake-fractals, and gentle swirling frost patterns depending on who looks at it.

Mechanical Effect

A spell scroll that never runs out — a one-page grimoire. Cast one of the following once per long rest without using a spell slot: • Frost Fingers (cold-themed Burning Hands) • Snowstep (as Misty Step, but the caster briefly becomes swirling flurries) • Frozen Ward (as Shield, but appears as a burst of crystalline frost) Each time you cast from the Codex Fragment, the runes change slightly, as though rewriting themselves.

Flavor

Nicholas calls it 'an old trick from an older age.' The magic inscribed on it is older than arcane theory itself.

Future Hook

The fragment is part of a larger volume — the Codex Borealis — lost somewhere across the planes.

ROCK GNOME ROGUE

The Tinsel-Twister Toolkit

A tiny copper-and-silver gear-box the size of a walnut, wrapped with a miniature ribbon that's impossible to remove unless the gnome wishes it. When tapped, the lid pops open with clockwork charm.

Mechanical Effect

Inside: a collapsible set of thieves' tools, a frost-tipped screwdriver, a spool of shimmering mithril-tinsel wire, and a single pine-scented smoke pellet. • Advantage on checks to use thieves' tools in cold

environments or on frozen objects. • Once per long rest: activate the Tinsel Wire to create a 10-ft trip line that glitters like ice. The first creature to cross makes a DC (8 + Prof + Dex) Dex save or falls Prone. • The pine-smoke pellet acts as Fog Cloud centered on you in a 10-ft radius.

Flavor

Nicholas made the kit himself, muttering something about how 'gnomes do better with proper gear.'

Future Hook

The tinsel wire is the same material used in ancient elven holiday artifacts. Your gnome may start wondering why Nicholas has access to it.

DWARF DRUID

The Evergreen Emblem

A carved wooden medallion shaped like a snowflake entwined with pine needles and stone runes. The Snowmouse familiar curls up on it whenever the druid sleeps.

Mechanical Effect

• Your Wild Shape forms gain 2 temporary hit points when you transform. • Once per long rest: use Speak with Animals without a spell slot. Animals understand not just your words but your intent, allowing more complex communication. • Your familiar gains resistance to cold damage and glows faintly in moonlight.

Flavor

Nicholas carved this by hand long ago and kept it as a symbol of balance between winter and wilderness.

Future Hook

The emblem is keyed to a fey winter lodge hidden deep in another plane. Your familiar instinctively knows how to find it.

WOOD ELF RANGER

The Silverpine Bowstring

A strand of shimmering silver-green fiber made from enchanted pine needles spun into thread. When strung onto any bow, it radiates soft winter light.

Mechanical Effect

• Your bow's range increases by +20 ft. • Once per short or long rest: when you hit a creature with a ranged attack, deal an extra 1d6 cold damage and reduce the target's speed by an additional 10 ft (stacking with Slow for a total of -20 ft). • While outdoors, you always know the direction of true north.

Flavor

Nicholas harvested the pine that became this bowstring from a tree older than recorded elven history.

Future Hook

A grove of Silverpine trees still grows somewhere in the world — but only rangers blessed by winter magic can find it.

APPENDIX: ELF NAMES

The Original Four

These are the elves the party followed from the cave. Use them as named NPCs if the party asks.

Name	Notes
Wizzle Brandywhistle	The leader. Quick to talk, quicker to worry.
Whittle Bramblemint	Obsessed with organization. Hates when things are out of place.
Fipple Hollycrank	The oldest of the four. Has seen a lot. Doesn't say much.
Nimble Sparklegrip	The youngest. Enthusiastic about everything. Scares easily.

Workshop Elves

These names can be used for any elf the party meets in the workshop, cellar, or kitchen. Roll a d20 or choose freely.

1. Kip Snowspindle	2. Snowble Stitchwhistle	3. Tinka Merrygear
4. Pip Sugarplank	5. Lolly Hearthbinder	6. Crimble Gearfizz
7. Pepper Twillthorn	8. Jolly Pockpocket	9. Merrin Nuttersprocket
10. Flicker Snowsproing	11. Bramble Peppermint	12. Tilly Morningsprocket
13. Crispin Janglewick	14. Doodle Frostfuse	15. Poppy Winterwhirl
16. Sprig Glitterstitch	17. Bramble Tinseltoe	18. Candle Gleamhopper
19. Merry Fizzlenut	20. Bram Tinkleforge	21. Sprock Tinkertwice
22. Glimmer Sweetsprocket	23. Taffy Coppergleam	24. Puzzle Snowtwist
25. Winnery Janglesnow		

APPENDIX: DM NOTES

Core Principles

- Death saves are private to the DM only.
- Players only roll dice when there is a clear consequence to failure.
- Investigative rolls like Perception are made by the DM — players don't get extra information from seeing the die result.
- Every failed roll is a soft nudge forward, never a brick wall.
- The party is not obligated to be heroic. Let them be mercenary. The story will make heroes of them regardless.

Tone Management

The Holiday Heist lives in a specific tonal register: comedic on the surface, genuine underneath. The elves should be funny and endearing. The castle should feel cozy and strange. Krampus should feel like a real threat. Nicholas, when he finally appears, should feel like the real deal — ancient, kind, and quietly terrifying to anything evil.

Don't force the drama. Let the players joke. The moment they see the caged elves and the imprisoned Nicholas, the jokes will naturally quiet down on their own.

Using the Hearthstar Core

The Core is the mechanical throughline of the second-floor encounter. Encourage players to use it. When they do, something exciting happens — Krampus reacts to it viscerally, the room brightens, and the narrative momentum shifts in the party's favor. Reward clever Core usage with concrete mechanical effects, not just flavor.

Nicholas as an NPC

Nicholas is not a deus ex machina. In his weakened form, he is a meaningful but non-decisive ally. He stabilizes characters at 0 HP (Faltering Light). He provides tactical support. He makes the players feel less alone. But the players win this fight — Nicholas just makes sure they survive it.

FUTURE HOOKS
Krampus flees but does not die. He will return. The Hearthstone glows when he is near.
The Codex Borealis is lost across the planes — a future artifact hunt.

The tinsel wire in the Rogue's toolkit comes from ancient elven holiday artifacts. Why does Nicholas have this?
The Evergreen Emblem knows the path to a fey winter lodge in another plane.
The Silverpine grove still exists. Only rangers blessed by winter magic can find it.
Nicholas himself may become a patron for any character who served the light at his darkest hour.

May your dice roll true, and your holiday be saved.